

Rains of Prophecy

Teo was sipping his coffee and did not hear Lena calling him. The storm raging outside had kept them indoors for two days. The wind was too loud for them to call to each other from separate rooms. Realizing he could not hear her, Lena left the kitchen and went into the living room, where Teo sat drinking his coffee.

“Do you know how much longer this storm will last?”

Teo raised one eyebrow over his coffee. “No, but I’m running out of spare cigarettes. The sooner it dies down, the better.” He went on sipping.

Lena sat on the arm of his chair and put her arms around him. Teo was looking at the bookcase. He turned his gaze to Lena and kissed her on the lips. His eyes left hers and returned to the books.

“Have you read all of these?”

Lena hesitated at the question. “Hmm, not all of them, but most. Why?”

Teo smiled and turned to her. “The Andromedes Prophecy.” He pointed to the book at the far right of the third shelf. “Have you read this one?”

Lena got up from the arm of the chair and went to fetch it. “I don’t think so. If I have, I don’t remember.” She took the book down and ran her fingers over its cover. She smelled it, holding the scent of a new book inside her for a moment. “It hasn’t been read. It’s never even been opened. I don’t remember buying it.”

As she carried the book back to Teo, lightning struck very close by, hitting the tree in their garden. Startled by the sudden flash and the sound, Lena dropped the book. It fell onto the table beside Teo’s coffee, and some of the coffee spilled over it. As Teo tried to wipe up the spill, he read the words on the back cover.

“The gods will choose someone to set right a world gone wrong. This person will be born again and enfold the world in his wings. He will change it and heal it. He will please the gods. We have given this nameless hero a name. Andromedés: the prophecy of the one who will carry the world to another galaxy.”

As Teo read on, lost in thought, he became aware of Lena’s screams. He looked up at her, still wiping the back of the book with his hands. She was pointing at the window opposite. The tree in their garden had begun to burn.

“HAJE is burning!”

This time, Lena’s cries reached him clearly. The magnificent sight of the burning tree cast a little light into the night. Looking closely at it, Teo noticed two things. The first was that what fell through the storm was not rain. Until Haje began to burn, only rain had been falling. Now frogs, tadpoles, fish, and all manner of insects were raining from the sky, but there was not a drop of water among them. The din outside, the sound of hail, came from the falling animals. He had never seen anything like it. He had heard of animals falling from the sky, but he had never thought he would see it himself.

The second thing Teo noticed was that Haje was leaning toward the house as it burned. Their home stood no chance against a plane tree as magnificent as Haje. If it fell, it would bring the house down with them inside. They had to get out at once. Teo’s voice cut through Lena’s screams and rose above the roar of the storm.

“Put something on and go to Polly’s. Hurry. Haje’s going to fall on us.”

Lena nodded and rushed upstairs. He should have been hurrying, yet a strange calm had settled inside him. While he waited for her, he took another sip of coffee and watched the fire. He could smell the burning animals raining down on Haje. The fire burns differently on these animals, he thought.

Lena came down the stairs so fast she almost tumbled. Teo pulled on his cardigan, and they left the house. They huddled into their coats and clung to each other. With difficulty, they made their way to their next-door neighbor Polly’s door. Lena knocked.

While they waited for Polly to answer, Teo let go of Lena and whispered in her ear. “There’s something I have to do. I’ll be right back. Don’t worry about me. I love you.” He kissed her on the lips. He was not sure she had heard him over the storm, but after the kiss, he was certain she understood.

He left her and walked toward Haje, approaching the burning tree. The sharp stench of dead, burned animals, of torn flesh and vaporized blood, mingled with the smell of Haje burning. Together they made a singular smell, unbearable to breathe. Teo endured it all the same. He held it in his lungs.

Haje had been here when Teo was a child. Even then, its trunk had been enormous, its crown far beyond his reach. The grown-ups used to say it had stood here for centuries. As a child, he had imagined the gods sitting beneath trees like this to rest. He had stopped believing that when he grew up. People had been born, grown old, and died. Haje had always remained. Teo knew it would still be here after he was gone.

He paid his respects to Haje as it died. His eyes returned to the flames consuming the animals. They burned orange and blue instead of orange and red. He approached a burning frog and threw soil over it. Then, as he picked it up, he heard a tremendous sound. The storm intensified. The ground shook. He fell onto his back and stared at the sky.

Among the clouds, he saw a human silhouette, bearded and majestic, holding a trident.

“Poseidon.” His voice was barely audible, but he was certain of what he saw. He recognized the weapon, the majesty, the beard. The shaking earth and the gathering force of the storm told him who stood among the clouds at its center. He had seen him in books. He had mocked the people who had once believed in these gods. He knew Poseidon.

A few seconds later, the vision vanished. Teo scrambled up and fled toward Polly’s house. As he ran, lightning flashed ever more frequently overhead. Night turned to day in an instant, and a bolt struck him.

Teo turned to ash. Animals were still falling, yet none landed on his ashes. After a while, an eagle fell from the sky into them, the first eagle to appear. The ashes suddenly flared blue. They began to burn more brightly than Haje. The blue flames began to take Teo’s shape. His body kept burning. Two wings began to emerge from his back. His human feet had given way to eagle’s feet burning blue. The flames on his body went out, and it returned to its former appearance, but his wings and feet continued to burn.

Suddenly, he began to scream. “Why am I still alive? I died. I know I did. I felt the nothingness. Why am I still alive?” Pain made his screams falter. When he raised his eyes, what he saw silenced his cries and stopped his tears.

Zeus stood before him with a thunderbolt in his hand. Just behind Zeus, to his right, stood Poseidon with his trident.

“You are alive because I permit it.”

Zeus’s voice was like a mountain speaking. It rose from the depths, majestic and soothing. It inspired trust.

“You will destroy this world and build another because I demand it of you.”

Teo disliked taking orders, yet this time he did not hear the words as commands. He did not feel his freedom had been insulted. He accepted the existence of something greater than himself. He did not question the orders at all. He did not know how to carry them out, but the strength in Zeus’s voice assured him he could do everything the god said.

“Fly.” Zeus’s voice rang through the heavens, and Teo began to fly.

“Rise.” Poseidon’s voice was as calm as still water, but his command was firm. “Go to the center of the storm.”

Teo flew toward the storm’s center. He passed among animals colliding in the sky and bodies torn apart, until he reached it. Here, he found a sight very different from the gods he thought he had seen on the ground. Reservoirs of light shone around him, manifesting as lightning in the world beyond. Zeus was far more magnificent than he had first appeared. The king of the gods sat on his throne in the heart of the storm, holding his thunderbolt. Poseidon stood beside him. His majesty was not equal to Zeus’s, but it was enough to bring Teo to his knees. Teo landed on the clouds and knelt.

Zeus spoke first. “Choose a name for yourself, ascended one! Choose a name worthy of what you have become. Bear that name!”

Teo thought for a while. He asked permission to lift his head. When it was granted, he raised his head and spoke a name.

“MENTUROS.”

The moment the name left his lips, Menturos burst into flame again. Fire covered his entire body. He shone like a blue star in the midst of the storm.

“Your name has accepted you. Good,” said Zeus.

Poseidon nodded his approval of the name. “You are ready for your task. Descend, and raise this world along with yourself.”

Poseidon spoke calmly, but Zeus followed his words with another majestic cry. “Tear it down and build it anew if you must. Burn it and bring it forth from its ashes. You are the one who will change this world.”

Menturos nodded. The storm subsided. The animals and lightning vanished from the sky. The gods were gone, and Menturos shone alone in the heavens. He descended to change the world, far faster than he had risen.